

I guess she wasn't buying the niece story.

Vivian was much more perceptive, but I was willing to accept it at face value. Kimmel asked me a lot of questions about blackjack and then asked me to demonstrate the system. After a couple of hours, he decided to go ahead.

After your book *Beat the Dealer*, which revealed your blackjack system to the public, was published and became a best seller, were the casinos beginning to lose money as a result?

What happened was this: There were a number of really good players, maybe a thousand or so, who extracted money from the casinos. Then there was a much larger number of players who used the basic strategy, so they could play much longer without losing as much. And finally, there was a much larger number of people who heard that you could beat the game, but were poor players. As a result of an influx of new players, blackjack became the most popular casino game. The casinos might have had a thousand or so blackjack players who made \$100,000 or \$200,000 a year and maybe 10,000 players who weren't losing as much. But, on other hand, they might have had 1 million players who thought they could win when they couldn't and were losing more because they were playing longer. The upshot was that the casinos really had a good thing, but they thought it was a bad thing. They started a war with the card counters. They tried to ban them. They beat up some of them.

Do you know people who were beat up?

Oh, yeah, Ken Uston was a well-known blackjack team player who was taken into the back room and had his cheek broken. He wrote a book about his experiences. There were also books by other people. The casino brutality was pretty well documented. Did you ever see a movie called *Casino*?

Sure. Was the depiction of Las Vegas in that movie accurate?

Yes, very much so. That's the way it was in the 1970s. In the 1960s, when I was playing, it was worse.

And yet you had no fear?

Well, I didn't know a lot of this stuff then.